

A weekly review of national and South Yorkshire developments in education policy, inclusion, SEND, behaviour and accountability — weighted to primary and evidence sources, with links and a clear “so what for your school” line on the items that matter.

Useful? Forward it to a colleague. To join the circulation or partner with the network, [get in touch](#).

TOP LINE

- The NEU's national executive stood down its planned strike ballot on 24 September after the DfE confirmed schools can keep the roughly £500m freed up by lower pension contributions to fund the 3.5% pay award, rather than having it clawed back centrally — resolving the cliffhanger flagged in last issue.
→ **For your school:** *Stand down any strike-contingency planning, but keep the pension-savings underspend earmarked for the pay award rather than folding it into general reserves.*
- West Sussex County Council will still face a £147m Dedicated Schools Grant deficit even after a fresh £183m of government support — a stark local illustration of how far the national High Needs Stability Grant is from actually closing SEND funding gaps.
→ **For your school:** *Worth raising with your own LA's finance team as a benchmark when they report on progress against their SEND reform plan.*
- Ofsted's latest published Sheffield report — for Wisewood Nursery & Primary — rated the school a 'strong standard' for inclusion, an early live example of inclusion now being inspected and graded as its own distinct area under the September 2026 framework.
→ **For your school:** *Read the report if you want a concrete sense of what 'strong standard' inclusion practice looks like under the new grading structure.*
- Schools that haven't yet submitted their PE and sport premium digital expenditure return have until 5pm Wednesday 30 September, per this week's DfE Update — a shorter, simplified form than in previous years.
→ **For your school:** *Check with whoever holds the PE premium budget that the return has actually gone in; the window is short.*

DATES FOR THE DIARY

30 Sep 2026 — Deadline for schools to submit their PE and sport premium digital expenditure reporting return.

2 Nov 2026 — Extended deadline for completing FSM autumn-census eligibility checks (carried over from last issue).

NATIONAL POLICY

- **A quieter week for top-down policy.** After last week's School Food Standards overhaul and the twin SEND consultations closing, no major new standalone DfE policy announcement landed this week — this issue's biggest national story is the pay/pension funding resolution, covered under Funding below.

FUNDING

- **NEU stands down the strike ballot due to open 3 October.** The union's national executive met on 24 September and agreed to stand the ballot down after education secretary Lucy Powell confirmed schools can keep — rather than have clawed back centrally — the roughly £500m freed up by a fall in employer pension contributions, using it to fund the 3.5% pay award in full. General secretary Daniel Kebede called

it a sign the government is 'willing to put its money where its mouth is', while warning the NEU expects further funding action to follow. ([LBC](#))

→ **For your school:** *Stand down any strike-day contingency planning, but keep the pension-savings underspend ring-fenced for the pay award pending the NEU's next move.*

■ **PE and sport premium return due 30 September.** This week's DfE Update to local authorities reminds schools that the digital expenditure reporting return for the 2025/26 PE and sport premium — significantly shorter than previous years' — must be completed and submitted by 5pm on Wednesday 30 September. ([GOV.UK \(DfE Update, 23 September 2026\)](#))

→ **For your school:** *A quick check with your PE lead now avoids a last-minute scramble next Wednesday.*

■ **£147m DSG deficit remains in West Sussex despite £183m top-up.** Even after receiving £183m in government support this year, West Sussex County Council still projects a £147m Dedicated Schools Grant deficit — a sobering reminder that the High Needs Stability Grant, which covers 90% of historic deficits for councils with an approved SEND reform plan, isn't designed to close ongoing in-year gaps. It's a useful read-across for any MAT or school watching its own LA's high-needs budget position. ([Sussex Express](#))

→ **For your school:** *If your LA hasn't shared where it stands against its SEND reform plan and deficit trajectory, this is a reasonable moment to ask.*

■ INCLUSION & SEND

■ **EOTAS and local SEND formula consultations now closed — response awaited.** Both twin consultations flagged in last issue — on oversight of education otherwise than at school, and on a local SEND inclusion formula letting councils raise the long-frozen £6,000 top-up threshold — closed on 18 September with no government response yet; one is expected in the coming weeks, with any changes taking effect from April 2027 at the earliest. In the meantime, councils' access to the separate High Needs Stability Grant (covering 90% of historic DSG deficits) remains conditional on a DfE-approved local SEND reform plan, tying this week's funding and inclusion stories together. ([GOV.UK](#))

→ **For your school:** *No immediate action needed, but flag the April 2027 implementation date to whoever manages your SEND top-up funding conversations with the LA.*

■ BEHAVIOUR, EXCLUSIONS & ATTENDANCE

■ **Rotherham Schools Forum's exclusions and reduced-timetables papers still not public.** Friday 18 September's Rotherham Schools Forum agenda included the annual exclusion & suspensions report, a reduced-timetables annual report and an EHCP update, but the supporting papers hadn't been published on the council's site by this issue's deadline, so there are no fresh figures to report this week. ([Rotherham MBC \(Schools Forum forward plan\)](#))

→ **For your school:** *Worth asking your Schools Forum rep directly for the headline exclusion and reduced-timetable figures if you need them sooner.*

■ OFSTED & ACCOUNTABILITY

■ **Inclusion's new status as a standalone graded area starts showing up in reports.** From this September, inspectors grade inclusion as its own distinct area rather than folding it into wider judgements — and Sheffield's Wisewood Nursery & Primary (see below) is an early local example of what a 'strong standard' inclusion grade actually looks like in practice, alongside expected-standard grades elsewhere in the same report.

■ SAFEGUARDING & WELLBEING

■ **Another quiet week — no new national announcement.** Schools remain in the early weeks of embedding KCSIE 2026's expanded duties (AI-generated content risks, the removal of the supervision exemption, mobile-phone-free defaults); nothing new landed nationally this week, so this is a reasonable moment to check those policy updates have actually been signed off rather than just diarised.

■ SHEFFIELD & SOUTH YORKSHIRE

▪ **Wisewood Nursery & Primary rated 'strong standard' for inclusion.** Ofsted's newly published report for the INOVA Multi-Academy Trust school — inspected in the summer, published this week — found a 'strong standard' in early years, inclusion, and personal development and wellbeing, and an 'expected standard' elsewhere, with safeguarding confirmed as met. Inspectors described 'a warm, family feel to the school'; head of school Claire Austin said the report recognises 'a school where every child is known, valued and given the support they need'. ([The Star](#))

→ **For your school:** A useful local benchmark if you're writing up your own inclusion strategy ahead of the 31 December publication deadline.

▪ **Rotherham Schools Forum met, but outcomes aren't public yet.** See Behaviour, exclusions & attendance above — Friday's forum covered exclusions, reduced timetables and EHCPs, but papers weren't available by this issue's deadline.

THIS WEEK'S NUMBER

£147m — the Dedicated Schools Grant deficit West Sussex County Council still projects despite receiving £183m in government support this year. It's a reminder that even generous headline funding announcements often leave a substantial local shortfall behind.

MAPS IN PRACTICE – TOOL SPOTLIGHT: SCHOOL+

A strong inclusion strategy is only as good as the cohort picture beneath it.

School+ is the MAPs cohort-vulnerability framework — it maps who your at-risk pupils are and why, giving your inclusion strategy an evidence base rather than a wish list. [Explore School+](#)

SOURCES MONITORED

Weighted official- and evidence-first. X is monitored for early signals from official accounts and named commentators, and corroborated against a primary source before anything is included.

Source	Type	What we track
OFFICIAL & STATUTORY		
DfE / GOV.UK	Government	Policy, funding, statutory guidance and statistics
Ofsted	Government	Inspection framework, report cards, annual report
Explore Education Statistics	Government data	Exclusions, suspensions, attendance, census data
House of Commons Library	Parliament	Neutral briefings on bills and policy
RESEARCH & EVIDENCE		
Education Endowment Foundation	Research	Evidence-based guidance, incl. inclusive teaching
NFER	Research	Assessment, workforce, disadvantage
Education Policy Institute	Think tank	Policy analysis and the disadvantage gap
Institute for Fiscal Studies	Think tank	School funding and spending analysis
FFT Education Datalab	Data analysis	Data-driven analysis of attainment and exclusions
INCLUSION & PREVENTION SPECIALISTS		
The Difference	Charity	Whole-school inclusion; "Who's Losing Learning?"
IPPR	Think tank	Lost learning, exclusions, SEND reform
Youth Endowment Fund	Research	What works to prevent youth violence & exclusion
Centre for Social Justice	Think tank	Exclusion tracker and social-mobility policy
Whole School SEND	Network	SEND practice, resources and reviews
SECTOR PRESS & COMMENTARY		
Schools Week	Press	Breaking sector news and investigations
Tes	Press	Practice, policy and workforce
The Guardian (Education)	Press	National coverage and comment

Source	Type	What we track
X (monitored)	Social	DfE, Ofsted, EEF and named voices — corroborated before use
LOCAL & REGIONAL		
The Star (Sheffield)	Local press	Local schools and Ofsted outcomes
Sheffield City Council	Local government	Council decisions, funding and local strategy
South Yorkshire MCA & Careers Hub	Regional	Regional skills, careers and funding

Connect Weekly is part of Sheffield Connect. Compiled by Andy Marsden, Sector Inclusion Lead.

For circulation across the network and partners. Figures reflect the latest published data at the date of this brief.